

Liquid Mini: a budget Android smartphone launched

Acer has launched an economical Android smartphone, the Liquid Mini, for Rs 11,990. A stripped down version of the original Liquid, it runs on FroYo and features an 8.1 cm (3.2") touchscreen (480 X 320 pixels), a 600 MHz processor, 512 MB of RAM, a 5MP camera (480p video-recording), a 32 GB expandable slot (2 GB card included), Bluetooth, GPS, FM, Wi-Fi and DLNA connectivity. Its battery capacity is 1300 mAh (6.5 hours talktime), and it lets you view and edit MS Office files with support for MS Exchange.



Soon, a faster Firefox for Linux users

Mozilla will soon come out with a new version of its Firefox Web browser for the Linux operating system platform that will be much faster than its predecessors. A group of Mozilla developers has finally managed to integrate Firefox's Linux builds with the GNU Compiler Collection (GCC) version 4.5.



"We finally managed to get our Linux (and, obviously, Linux64) builds to use GCC 4.5, with aggressive optimisation (-O3) and it has profile guided optimisation enabled," developer Mike Hommey recently blogged. "This means we are finally using a more modern toolchain, opening up opportunities for things such as static analysis. This also means we are now producing a faster Firefox, which is much closer to the Windows builds on the same hardware, on various performance tests."

Hommey doesn't expect the feature to appear officially until Firefox 6; however, the newly improved builds should work on older Linux platforms as well, including Red Hat and CentOS 5.

UK developer creates a thumb-sized, \$23 PC

Imagine a computer that's the size of a USB stick and costs just \$23. David Braben, the UK-based game developer, has created a thumb-sized computer for school children, which is based around a USB stick called the Raspberry Pi. With its USB port on one side and HDMI port on the other, it can function as a real PC. This allows a keyboard and a monitor to be connected respectively.

The small size doesn't mean that the PC lacks specs—in fact, there's enough room for a 700 MHz ARM11 processor, 128 MB of RAM and OpenGL graphics with ample power to display 1080p video.

On its website, the Raspberry Pi Foundation says, "We plan to develop, manufacture and distribute an ultra-low-cost computer, for use in teaching computer programming to children. We expect this computer to have many other applications both in the developed and the developing world."

You can use Braben's little PC to browse the Web at reasonable speeds and do basic PC tasks such as word processing. The computer comprises a 12 megapixel camera module, an SD card slot for storage, and that's where you install the operating system of your choice.

Braben intends to launch the first Raspberry Pi device within the next 12

Now, turn your Android phone into a remote control

At its I/O developer conference in San Francisco, Google showed off a future scenario in which you could use an Android phone to control home appliances—to turn on and off the lights, the dishwasher or anything else you wanted to. The technology called Android@Home would be built into appliances so that they could wirelessly communicate with Android devices—it would work similar to the way a Bluetooth headset communicates with a mobile phone. Developed as an open wireless protocol, Android@Home will allow the OS to connect with devices that are powered by electricity.

"Think of your phone as the nucleus that this all started with," Joe Britt, engineering director, Google said. He went on to add, "We're opening the platform up to everyone to do whatever they can imagine. We'd like to think of your entire home as an accessory, or better yet, as a network of accessories, and think of Android as the operating system for your home."

While demonstrating the technology,



Britt used a Motorola Xoom tablet to control stage lights created by Lighting Science Group—Google's first officially announced partner. By the end of this year, the LED manufacturer will release the first Android@Home-capable LED light bulbs.

Google also previewed the Open Accessory toolkit at the conference for hobbyist developers, who don't make washing machines or light bulbs but can make other things that work with Android devices.